

Family Secrets

an adventure by Bill Sweeney

for 4-6 characters of 2nd-4th level

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Introduction

Many years ago, when you were but children growing up in the peaceful countryside north of Waterdeep, you would spend your long summer days playing near the warm banks of the Neverwinter River, laughing and enjoying the company of your friends as you pretended you were powerful adventurers exploring the all the hidden nooks and crannies along the riverside.

During many of those early summers, wealthy children from the noble families of Waterdeep would travel up to Neverwinter to get out of the City of Splendors during the hottest months of the year, to live with the relatives and friends of their affluent parents. Many of these children were spoiled rotten and you and the poorer children of Neverwinter decidedly played far away from them. However, one of these young nobles did find her way into your group of make-believe adventurers, a young girl named Lythis Mhairuun who had long golden hair and a kind heart that matched her smile.

Lythis became a good friend to all of you during those childhood years and it was indeed a pity when all of you became older and she had too many responsibilities in Waterdeep to travel up to Neverwinter every summer. Soon her letter ceased to come and it seemed as if she had drifted out of all your lives, much like many old friends do. You happened to hear about a year ago, from her aunt whom which she stayed with as a child, that Lythis had married a nobleman in Waterdeep and that since her father had passed away sometime before, that the Mhairuun family had been absorbed by the marriage.

This being the only news of your friend in the last five years, all of you were more than surprised to receive a letter from your friend this day, as you sat in your favorite tavern near Lord Nasher's Palace. The letter is addressed to all of you and is stamped with a strange and unknown wax seal.

The seal is that of the Phylund family crest. Allow the characters to have a copy of the letter as shown below,

Dear friends,

I know it has been much too long since I have last written you, but my memories of all of you remain strong and vivid in my heart. In the past weeks, I have thought of you often, and have regretted how we have drifted away from each other over the years. As you have undoubtedly heard from my aunt, I married a nobleman here in Waterdeep and am now heavy with child. Things are not as wonderful here as they may seem though, and it would make me very happy if all of you could come and visit so that we may catch up on the old days. If you accept my invitation, you can call on me at the home of my husband's family, the Phylund family villa located in the North Ward of the city. I hope to see you soon, my love as always...

Lythis Phylund

The characters may equip themselves as needed before heading south to Waterdeep.

Arrival

Several days later, you find yourselves on the road heading south to Waterdeep, the summer sun beating warmly down upon you backs. The trip from Neverwinter was without incident, mostly due to the fact of the green-cloaked Waterhavian patrols that guard this well traveled road. It is the middle of the afternoon when the outer walls of the City of Splendors rise up from the rugged coast, dwarfed by the majesty of Mt. Waterdeep which overlooks the city like a protective giant. A crowd of merchants and farmers crowd the north gate and you can see the throngs of people milling about in the streets beyond the guardhouses. Though many of you have visited Waterdeep on occasion, the city is truly massive and you ask the gate guard, a proud-looking woman dressed in silver scale mail, directions to the Phylund villa. After paying your group's gate fee of a single gold piece, you are given instructions to find the estate in the southeastern corner of the North Ward.

Pushing your way through the crowds of people from all corners of Faerun, and making several wrong turns along the way, you find yourself standing in front of a beautiful ivy-covered estate in one of the most affluent areas in all of Waterdeep. Two guardsmen, wearing the same symbol that marked the wax seal, stand at attention outside the iron-worked fence that separates the city from the flowery courtyard in the center of the estate.

Phylund Noble Villa (N40)

The guards will let the party pass if they show the letter from Lythis. They are directed to the large southeastern building to find the Lady Phylund. As the characters enter the courtyard, they will see a young child using a slingshot to hit songbirds in one of the trees. Several birds lay dead at his feet already and any attempt to scold or speak to the child will bring upon the wrath of his mother, Aridarye. Aridarye will storm out of the northern mansion if the characters approach the boy, Urtos the III, and scream at them for disciplining her child. Aridarye is voluptuous and very young, with dark black tresses always hanging long down her back. Aridarye will demand to know the characters business in the villa and will go as far as to call the guards to expel them. At this point Lythis will emerge from the southern house to welcome the characters.

The double doors on the southern home open suddenly and a beautiful woman with pale blond hair waddles forth, obviously in some discomfort and very much pregnant. When you see her face you realize that it you old friend Lythis and that she seems furious.

"Aridarye! These are my guests and as Lady of the Manor I decide who stays and who leaves. You know as well as I do that my husband has told your son to stop killing every innocent animal that finds its way into the gardens. If I had my choice, you and you twisted son would be the ones to leave regardless of the fact that your stepson feels sorry for you. Now be gone, or I will have to tell Urtos about this."

You watch as the raven haired woman stares back at Lythis with burning hatred before turning and stalking back into the northern building, dragging her screaming son behind her. This woman must not be much older than you and Lythis, but her demeanor and cold graces leave the impression of a cruel old maid.

"It is so good to see all of you, I didn't think you would come. I'll explain all of that later, but now please, come and meet my husband." Lythis gives each of you a hug over her bulging belly and then leads you, waddling as she goes, into the southern building, a magnificent stone house covered with green vines and flowers. You step through the double doors and into a dazzling dining room with a dark mahogany table and a great silver chandelier hanging from the ceiling. From the far end of the room, a strikingly handsome man

strides forward to meet you, his body muscled and a long mane of golden hair trailing behind him. Lythis introduces her husband to you as Urtos Phylund, and as you each shake his hand you can seem a sadness in his eyes beneath his polite smile.

"Welcome to my home, each of you are may to stay as long as you wish. I have heard much about all of you and if your friends of Lythis then your friends of mine. I'm very sorry but I have some business to attend to so I will meet you tonight for dinner." Urtos kisses his wife on the cheek and then quickly exits the double doors and out into the courtyard. Lythis stands silently watching him go, her frown indicating that all is not truly well.

"I'm sorry..., please, you must be tired, let us retire to the study so that we may talk."

The characters will be led up to the study on the second floor (area 14) and the DM can continue with Talking with Lythis. If the characters do something unexpected or want to rest first they will be escorted by the servants to the guest bedrooms in the northern house. Descriptions of all the areas of the estate are listed below;

1) Gate

This iron worked gate is the only (widely known) entrance to the estate. It is guarded at all times by two guards dressed in the livery of the family. During the day it is guarded by two older fighters named Grom (F2) and Halak (F2). During the night is stationed by two younger warriors; Nelle (F1) and Veldrig (F3). Both of these warriors know that Gast Brokengulf is a regular visitor to Aridarye at late hours of the night.

2) Courtyard

This beautiful courtyard is tended to by Nelle (see above) during the day. Flower beds full of violets and yellow snapdragons surround the mansions and a number of apple trees dot the courtyard which are favorite nesting places for songbirds when Urtos III isn't killing them.

3) Dining Hall

This is the official dining room of the estate since Urtos II and Lythis moved into the southern house. A long dark mahogany table and a silver chandelier decorate this fine room.

4) Sitting Room

Plush couches and duskwood tables cover the carpeted floor of this room. Silver serving trays and fine crystal lie in cabinets that stand under works of art on the walls. This is where the Phylund's normally entertain nobility.

5) Trophy Hall

Great tapestries depicting the Phylund crest as well as strange and magnificent creatures such as wyverns, dragons, and hippogriffs hang on the walls of this room. A statue of Taernos Phylund, founder of the family has been moved to this room and stands in the center of the mounted beast heads that hang from the walls. Bears, stags, giant cats, and even the skull of a long dead dragon are included in the collection.

6) Old Hall

This was once the main hall of the old estate until Urtos the I died this winter. Since then, the couches and chairs have been covered with cloths and a thick layer of dust has covered everything. Aridarye has demanded that none of the servants touch a thing here, and out of respect for his stepmother, Urtos the II has obeyed this order.

7) Cloak Room

Formally the cloak room to the old estate, nothing but an old woolen cloak hangs within this room. A silver key forgotten in the pocket opens the door to area 10.

8) Closet

This room used to be a storage area for the family's personal belongings and seasonal decorations. The door to this room is locked and behind it is only piles of unused furniture in storage,

9) Stairwell

These stairs leading up to the second level used to be decorated by sashes and garlands, but since Urtos the I has died, they remain bare and undecorated. The door to area 10 always remains locked and only Aridarye and Urtos the II have a key.

10) Shrine to Torm

The Phylund's were once dedicated to the worship of Torm but have since drifted away from the religion. An unused shrine and altar stand covered with dust in this room. Careful inspection of the dusty floor will show that there has been passage to and from both doors in room recently. The door to area 11 is locked and only Aridarye and Urtos the II have a key.

11) Crypt Entrance

A dusty stairwell leads downward to a landing ten feet square in area. The walls are smooth here except on the southern wall where a bas relief of the Phylund crest is engraved into the wall. Reaching into the fanged maw of the carving will reveal a lever that causes the wall to swing outward and providing access to the crypts below.

12) Kitchen

It is here that the family meals are prepared by the cook, a matronly old woman named Helga. The kitchen is always full of sweet scents and smells and there are usually servants buzzing through the area. Helga is a very quiet woman, but very observant and knows that Aridarye and Prendergast Brokengulf are having an affair.

13) Pantry

Numerous bags of foodstuffs and supplies crowd this packed little room.

14) Study

This room is filled with bookshelves and comfortable couches. It is here that Lythis will talk to the characters upon their arrival, The book collection is impressive and contains an number of rare works on the ecologies of strange beasts and methods of breeding and training them.

15) Master Bedroom

This silk and ivory decorated room is Lythis and Urtos' private bedchamber. The couple's personal possessions are stored in cabinets here but nothing is of any significance.

16) Private Study

This is Urtos the II's private study. Piles of books lie strewn about and covered in dust and a number of financial ledgers lay amidst the debris. Inspection of the papers will show that Urtos has sold most of the family businesses to a moneylender in the city named Mirt. The disuse of this office shows that it is rarely used.

17) Dressing Room

This is Lythis' personal chambers where she reads and sews when she is left alone by her husband. A number of romance stories lie stacked on a table next to a comfortable chair.

18 - 21) Guest Rooms

These rooms are given to the characters when they arrive. Area 19 has a washroom and privy and all the rooms are decorated sparsely but elegantly with silken sheets and fine art pieces.

22) Servants Quarters

It is here that the guards and servants sleep and live when they are off duty.

23) Aridarye's Library

This room is cramped and littered with books and maps of all sorts. The door to this room is always locked and only Aridarye has the key. Most of the books seem unused and are just historical texts. However, a careful inspection of the collection will reveal a number of them deal with herbalism and the manufacture of deadly poisons.

24) Living Chambers

This room was once a sunny living quarters, but the bay windows on the north wall have been covered by heavy drapes, casting the room into shadow. The furniture here is uncovered and used although the room remains cold and lifeless. The few decorations that are here are of Tethyrian design and seem mismatched and uncared for.

25) Child's Room

This is the room in which Urtos the III sleeps. He will be found her 50% of the time during the day. He has a wide collection of animal skulls kept in a

box under the bed and has taken an interest in polishing them to a shine in his free time.

26) Aridarye's Bedchamber

This is where Aridarye sleeps. She used to share this bedchamber with Urtos the I until he died last winter. There is a closet and washroom in the north wall that is well furnished. The bedroom itself is decorated in fine imported woods and silks and a number of jeweled statues stand around the room on pedestals. Mirrors cover the walls of the room in every possible location and sweet smelling perfumes dot the table tops. Aridarye keeps a poisoned dagger +2 straps to the back of her headboard. A coffer, hidden in a niche in the southern wall behind a mirror, is locked and trapped with a poison needle. Inside are three vials of assorted poisons and a bag of cut diamonds worth 10,000 gp. Aridarye can be found here 90% of the time during the day and 50% of the time at night. If she is here at night, 50% of the time, Gast Brokengulf will be here as well.

27) Guardian Hall

The stairs from area 11 lead down to this cobwebbed and musty room. There is a stale smell of decay here and rodent as well as human tracks cross through the dust here. In the recesses of the ceiling, three watchspiders lair, as guardians to the crypts and treasure chambers. If the characters enter the room, the watchspiders will drop from the ceiling above them and attack.

Watchspiders (3); AC 6; MV 18; HD 2+2, hp 16 each; THACO 19; Dmg 1d6 + paralytic poison; XP 420

28) Minor Crypts

These rooms contain a number of stone biers on which minor members of the family have been laid to rest. Only skeletal remains and tattered clothing now remain.

29) Major Crypt

This room is more decorated than the minor crypts and the stone biers are more elaborate. The remains of several of the heads of House Phylund lie in piles of bone and rotting cloth. A platinum ring is still on the skeletal hand of one of the bodies. The ring belonged to Urtos the II's great-grandfather Kronin Phylund and is a ring warmth.

30) Major Crypt

This room holds the remains of many house heads including those of Urtos the I. He was killed last winter by his wife Aridarye when she poisoned his wine with a potent injestive poison. His remains are only partially decayed and the smell of rot is still strong on him. Understandably, a cloth has been placed over the body. The poison Aridarye used was so strong that a priest casting detect poison on the corpse will detect its presence in the dead tissues. There is a secret door in the southern wall that can only be opened by the medallion Aridarye wears. This secret chamber is a family secret which Urtos the I shared with his second wife but never was able to share with his son. Aridarye has converted the chamber to her secret abode where she can worship her dark goddess Talona in private.

31) Treasure Chamber

The riches of House Phylund have been depleted over the years and this chamber pales in comparison to what it once held. Despite hard times, the vault still holds 10,546 gp, 21,567 sp, 50 trade bars worth 200 gp each, and assorted jewelry worth 12,300 gp. The door to this chamber is locked and only Urtos the II, much to Aridarye's chagrin, has a key.

32) Shrine to Talona

This dark chamber used to be a secret chamber used by the old Lord Phylund to sneak dangerous creatures up from the sewers. The former lord abandoned the practice when the city guard began to inquire how he was importing beasts into the city without the knowledge of the Lords. Urtos the I never got the chance to tell his son of the secret room, but Aridarye learned of it and stole the magical medallion that can magically open the secret door leading to this area. She has used this place as her temple to her dark goddess, Talona where she can plot to steal the Phylund family fortunes. There is a shrine to Talona against the west wall and a bowl of poison atop the altar next to seven gold wedding bands,. A number of dark green candles lie scattered around the room and old bloodstains cover the floor. A specially bred watchspider who can spin poisonous webs lairs in the hallway leading to the chamber. It has woven its paralytic web in such a manner that a traveler can pass through the hallway if very careful. If the characters enter from either the crypts or the sewers, the watchspider will attack.

Watchspider (1); AC 6; MV 18; HD 2+2, hp 18; THACO 19; Dmg 1d6 + paralytic poison; can spin webs made out of same poison; XP 620

At night, Aridarye can be found here 50% of the time, praying to Talona.

Talking with Lythis

Read this section when the characters follow Lythis up into the study and are able to relax on the soft couches in the room.

"I know we all have alot of catching up to do, and we will in time. I'm sure you all have questions for me and I'll try to explain to you some of the events of the last year, the events that lead to my marriage falling apart."

"You see, when I would spend the summers with you in Neverwinter, I would spend the winters here in Waterdeep with my wealthy friends. It was in those early years that I met Urtos, he was so kind and handsome, unlike many of the nobles in this city, and his family trained and bred monsters much like my father did for a living. Urtos' father, Urtos the I, was a kind and soft-spoken man whose first wife died in childbirth with my husband. He married the woman you met in the courtyard, Aridarye, about four years ago, she twice widowed and had moved to Waterdeep from Tethyr. What he ever saw in her, other than her figure, one could never guess, but soon after their marriage Urtos the III was born, the darling little boy you met in the courtyard."

"Several years later, when it became my time to marry, Urtos and I were best of friends already and our union seemed logical both romantically and economically for both families. My father sold his businesses, many of them raising watchspiders, to the my husband's father last summer before our wedding. Two weeks before the ceremony my husband disappeared on a hunting trip in Ardeep Forest with his friend Gast Brokengulf. Gast returned to Waterdeep alone and frantic and patrols of the guard were sent to scour the ancient forest for any sign of my beloved. Two weeks passed and there was no clues or sign of him.